Where You Are: The Medicaid Readiness Step and What Comes After It

The nine steps of the Medicaid Planning Roadmap, with yours marked.

When Mom already needs care and the bills are already arriving, it can feel as if the whole Medicaid question is yours to answer, alone. It isn't. There's an order to it, other people have a part in it, and you're at step three of nine.

This page shows the whole road, where you are on it, and what comes next.

Phase 1 · Assess

Understand where you are today.

1. **Understand** Care Needs → Levels of Care & Costs → Care Plan
   You finish with: Immediate Care Needs Assessment

2. **Organize** Income & Assets → Ownership & Expenses → Financial File
   You finish with: Financial Snapshot & Care Cost Analysis

3. **Assess** Care & Nonfinancial Eligibility → Income & Assets → Barriers & Readiness
   You finish with: Medicaid Readiness Assessment

   You are here. This step is about asking the Medicaid question properly. Your family gets what it knows about Mom's care, her income and assets, and anything that may need a closer look onto paper, and a professional reviews it against the rules in her state. The step is finished when you know where Mom currently stands, what may stand in the way, and what would need to be addressed before applying.

Phase 2 · Plan

Develop and implement your strategy.

4. **Plan** Barriers & Issues → Priorities & Professional Team → Written Plan
   You finish with: Medicaid Action Plan

5. **Legal** Authority & Documents → Property, Trusts & Transfers → Attorney Review
   You finish with: Legal Issues & Attorney Review Brief

6. **Financial** Costs & Runway → Asset Treatment & Tools → Strategy & Documentation
   You finish with: Financial Strategy & Implementation Plan

Phase 3 · Secure

Secure benefits, protect assets, and maintain eligibility.

7. **Apply** Prepare → Submit → Manage
   You finish with: Medicaid Application File

8. **Protect** What May Be Protected → What May Remain Exposed → What Needs Ongoing Attention
   You finish with: Asset Protection Report

9 **Maintain** Ongoing Requirements → Changes & Renewals → Maintenance System

You finish with: Medicaid Maintenance Plan

What this step produces

A Medicaid Readiness Assessment: a written picture set out as what appears okay, what needs attention, what information is missing, and which questions need a professional's review. The step moves from care and nonfinancial eligibility, to income and assets, to barriers and readiness, and it builds on the two steps before it: understanding Mom's care needs and getting her finances onto paper.

Your part is what your family knows, what it has only been told, and what it still needs to ask. The review itself belongs to a professional because, as the federal long-term care site puts it, eligibility rules and covered services vary from state to state. [1]

The assessment is a starting point for planning. It isn't a decision by the Medicaid agency, and it doesn't say that Mom will qualify.

What happens next

Your Medicaid planner reviews your family's care and financial information against the Medicaid rules that apply in Mom's state and care setting, and notes possible barriers, missing information and gaps in the paperwork before any application. Issues that can be handled administratively are separated from the ones that need an elder law attorney or a licensed financial professional.

Then comes step four, Plan, which turns what the review found into priorities, a professional team and a written plan. The legal and financial steps follow it, and the application itself is step seven. This page gives no dates for any of that: the federal long-term care site says the best time to apply depends on a person's medical situation, marital status and the complexity of her finances. [2]

Who is involved, by role

- You and your family: gathering, writing down, and keeping what you know apart from what you've only been told.
- Mom: what she knows and remembers about her own affairs, if she's able to tell you.
- The facility's business office or social worker: what the bill covers, and what they have on file about her care.
- Your Medicaid planner: reviews the picture against the rules that apply in Mom's state and care setting, and sorts what can be handled administratively from what needs another professional.
- An elder law attorney and a licensed financial professional: the legal and financial questions the review sends their way.
- The state Medicaid agency: takes the application, when there is one, and makes the eligibility decision.

What this page doesn't promise

How long any step takes, who will be available, or how things turn out. It doesn't say Mom will qualify for anything or that any amount will be protected, and it isn't legal, financial or tax advice. Families move through the steps at different speeds.

Ready for the next step?

You know where this step sits and what follows it. The planning interview is the next thing to do from here: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

Get Your Free Planning Report ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The nine steps are the Medicaid Planning Roadmap's own. The statements that rules vary from state to state, that the state takes the application and decides eligibility, and about the timing of an application come from the Administration for Community Living's long-term care pages below.

1. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare information), Medicaid
2. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare information), Applying for Medicaid

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